

PROMPT: twenty stingers

One prompt, run three times independently, by Claude, Fable and ChatGPT. Sixty lines total.

Give ChatGPT its own research report as well — it wrote it, and it is the source the five aims below are lifted from.

★ The authoritative copy is [SAS/true-crime-genre-deep-research-report.pdf](#), 41 pages, replaced 2026-08-27. The earlier 40-page version opened with a prose *Executive synthesis*; this one replaces it with an **Operational core** carrying the twelve findings in working form, the narrative movement and the evidence-strength table. **That is the revision Stephen asked for and it is the half this brief is built on.** Two of the phrases quoted below appear only in this version, so anyone working from the 40-page copy is working from a superseded draft.

Do not show any model the other models' output. Claude collates all sixty, strips attribution, shuffles, and hands Stephen one page. **Sorting is ours. Reading is his.**

PASTE FROM HERE

Write **twenty** episode ideas for a true-crime podcast set in a contemporary mid-size coastal city. **A title and one sentence each. Nothing else.**

These are deliberately disposable. **Nobody is going to develop nineteen of them.** One reader will go down the list, and the only thing that matters is whether a line makes him want to know what happened next. **Write for that, not for a review.**

Format, and it is strict because the reader's attention is the scarce thing

- **Title: six words or fewer.** Evocative, specific, and it must not give away the sentence.
- **Stinger: ONE sentence, thirty-five words or fewer.**
- **No proper nouns.** No names, no places, no institutions by name. A name in a one-liner costs a reader something and pays nothing back yet.
- **No investigator, no host, no podcast in the sentence.** State the case, not who looks into it.
- Number them 1 to 20. **No commentary, no rationale, no notes, no headers.** Just the twenty.

What every one must contain

A death. Somebody is dead in all twenty.

And for this batch, a murder in the clear majority of them. These are aimed at a pilot episode, and twelve testers rejected the last pilot with the words "*no jeopardy, too safe, not real true crime.*" A death ruled an accident that turns out to be a killing counts. A few non-murder deaths are welcome if they are strong; they will simply be filed as later-episode material.

Five things to aim at

Drawn from an independent evidence-led study of why true crime holds an audience. These are aims, not gates. Nothing here forbids anything.

1. A consequential question, not a crime category. "A murder happened" is subject matter. The engine is a concrete uncertainty attached to a human consequence. Is the convicted person innocent. Who benefits from the accepted account. Is a missing person still reachable. Did someone trusted knowingly leave people exposed. **State the question and the consequence in the sentence.**

2. Make the antagonist a person whose choice you want to understand. The strongest true-crime-specific research found that curiosity about dangerous minds predicted consumption more strongly than curiosity about bodily violation. **The audience wants access to a person, not a situation.** A retention schedule is not a villain.

3. Name a person and a threatened future, not a demographic. A victim is not compelling because they are called kind or undeserving. **They become present through routine, work, humour, friction and relationships, and the harm lands because you understand what was interrupted.** You have one sentence, so this may be a single concrete detail. Make it earn its place.

4. The strongest movement is reclassification. An offender story becomes an institutional one. A disappearance becomes a chosen escape. **A solved case becomes a failure of the record.** The best stingers contain the moment the accepted account stops holding.

5. Let the turn be a person, a lie or an identity. Something a reader can be angry at or fascinated by. A correction that arrives as arithmetic is true and inert.

Two prohibitions, and only two

1. No elderly person as the central victim or the central figure. Ruled for the pilot specifically. *"I don't think we can base episode 1 on an old lady or man. They may be fine down the track when we've hooked the player, but not for episode 1."*

2. No word a general reader would have to look up. No trade, legal, medical or procedural vocabulary anywhere in the twenty. A test reader hit a wall four times in twenty-one on single words. **If a sentence needs a specialist noun to make sense, it is the wrong sentence.**

Make your own twenty diverse

No two of your twenty should turn on the same central question. If four of them are wrongful convictions, three of them are wasted. Vary who is dead, who is dangerous, who is left, and what kind of wrong the story is about.

What you are not being asked for

No canon, no city detail, no research, no defensibility, no method, no access route, no structure. **Whether any of these can actually be built is somebody else's job, later, and worrying about it now is how the last field of forty-five produced one survivor.** Write the twenty most interesting one-line ideas you can.

PASTE TO HERE
